

Chapter 12

Education Hubs as a Development Approach. A Phenomenon with Geopolitical Implications in Singapore and the United Arab Emirates



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12.1 Introduction

The field of development economics has provided compelling evidence that social and economic development occurs when an expansion of peoples' freedoms is combined with constructing social and economic arrangements—or in other words, institutions (Sen, 1999; Acemoglu & Robinson, 2008; Chang, 2010). These institutions include well-organized bureaucracies, well-designed, binding legal frameworks ensuring equal rights, and public education as a central social institution that enables people to use their freedoms and become productive members of society (Sen, 1999; Klafki, 2019). The recent focus in both academia and policy on knowledge-based economies as a model for generating growth arguably affirms education's central role in development, particularly that of higher education and research (Godin, 2005; Jessop et al., 2008). More generally, this type of social, cultural, and economic development that has proven successful over the past decades is mostly associated with democracy as a form of government (Gerring et al., 2005; Acemoglu et al., 2014). Also, international and inter-governmental organizations (IOs) have been created to promote the expansion of peoples' freedoms and democracy, which has heavily influenced the geopolitical environments of the 20th and current 21st centuries (Reynaud & Vauday, 2009). Therefore, democracies with strong public institutions have arguably become today's preferred model for development that IOs promote, with several countries newly pursuing this route, as is seen in the European Union's recent "eastern enlargement" (European Parliament, 2020).

However, there are signs of alternative development paths that do not necessarily require the development of a country's social institutions (Barbier, 2003; Badia-Miro et al., 2015). For example, the Gulf monarchies, such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar,

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and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), are receiving heightened attention for their recent development pathways, which is paired with criticism for under-prioritizing institution building (Hvidt, 2011; Mohaddes et al., 2019). Thus, Gulf monarchies' current substitution of political institution building with market liberalization and infrastructure development financed by natural resource wealth is at risk of being short-lived (Rosser, 2009; Hvidt, 2011).

On a similar note, Singapore also presents a fascinating example since instead of developing its social and political institutions towards more inclusiveness, Singapore concentrated its efforts on developing its economic and "knowledge institutions (universities, public research institutes and corporate laboratories)" Koh, 2006, p. 144). Singapore promotes education as the key to its development and has positioned itself as a globally reputed location for higher education and research, an approach to development for which it has coined the term "education hub" (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014; Lee, 2015). Gulf monarchies such as Qatar and the UAE have begun adopting Singapore's education hub model, arguably because this development approach aligns with their current bypassing of institution building that, instead, would require structural changes (i.e., legal frameworks, freedoms, political system changes). Also, even though the education hub approach bypasses social and democratic institution building that is commonly central to strategies promoted by IOs and the development community, the same community endorses it and rewards hub countries with a reputation of being economically and socially progressive countries (British Council, 2013; OECD IMHE, 2014; Henderson, 2012; Quah, 2018).

Thus, the education hub phenomenon has geopolitical implications that are closely linked to development as well as policy making and higher education. In terms of geopolitics, countries pursuing the education hub model are likely seeking to decrease their dependence on powerful development institutions like IOs and the current approaches they promote. Simultaneously, by adopting this development approach, countries signal to their regional neighbors that they are attempting to play a more important role in competition. A hub—whether in aviation, banking, or education—commonly flourishes in an environment of voids. For example, countries with developed higher education and research systems have an advantage in a regional environment that lacks these, which makes education hubs like Singapore successful. Thus, geopolitically, the education hub approach produces winners and losers, inequalities, and potentially conflicts, while more generally reducing the influence of established players in development. The education hub approach also impacts the development landscape because established arguments of IOs and others promoting democratic institutional development may resonate less, and new players might emerge that oppose democratic institutional development altogether.

Even though these implications for geopolitics and development are important, this chapter focuses on some of the impacts that the implementation of education hub approaches have on policy making and higher education in Singapore and the UAE. Instead of development through social institution building, this approach rather relies on infrastructure development combined with a desired cultural change.

In addition to policy making, the chapter also touches on the role of universities that, historically, have been central to developing democracies, and institutions more generally (Fisch, 2015). Despite their history, European and American universities are some of today's major players in promoting education hubs in countries that have almost contrarian contexts compared to their home countries (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014). Thus, this begs questions about their role, identity, and the compromises they make, and what this means for faculty, students, and the societies in which they operate.

Against this background, this chapter *first* briefly provides some insights on the conceptual and methodological frameworks of the study; *second*, it summarizes the current state of the art of research on education hubs and describes the research gap it attempts to address. *Third*, it discusses higher education policy making in the cases Singapore and the UAE by tracing how these countries' education hub approaches were developed and implemented from the 1990s to the 2010s. *Last*, the chapter concludes by comparatively discussing higher education policy in both education hubs, seeing these as governance environments for universities, and what the approach and its local adoptions mean for both geopolitics and development more broadly.

12.2 Conceptual and Methodological Notes

The chapter is based on a larger dissertation project titled "International Education Hubs in the Global Education Industry. Changing Policy and Governance in Higher Education", conducted between 2016 and 2021 at the University of Münster, Germany. It aimed at comparatively exploring higher education policy making and governance in Singapore and the UAE by using the concept of 'International Education Hubs'. Thus, it posed two overarching research questions: *First*, what is the analytical potential of current international comparative higher education research concepts used to study the phenomenon? *Second*, how does the phenomenon change policy making and governance in international higher education? The observed phenomenon—for which the term *education hub* has been coined—is that countries such as Singapore have implemented government projects that aimed to transform the city-state into an economically more competitive and socially more progressive country by means of reforming education, in particular higher education. To help answer the posed research questions, the study used a Comparative Case Study approach (Bartlett & Vavrus, 2017) to compare phenomena along three axes:

The horizontal axis compares how similar policies unfold in distinct locations that are socially produced [...] and 'complexly connected' [...] The vertical axis insists on simultaneous attention to and across scales [...] The transversal comparison historically situates the processes or relations under consideration. (Bartlett & Vavrus, 2017a, p. 3)

Through its three axes and a processual understanding of ‘casing’, the approach provided useful tools to compare Singapore’s and the UAE’s education hub projects as two large, emergent cases.

Conceptually, it adopted Cultural Political Economy (Sum & Jessop, 2013) to explore the cultural (immaterial-semiotic) aspects of the education hub projects in combination with structural-material ones, and, contrary to traditional approaches in the study of political economy, analyzing both dimensions as equally important. Also, it helped to explore the desired cultural changes in countries’ economies and societies that governments attempt to achieve through higher education reform. In terms of methods, Critical Discourse Analysis (Fairclough, 2003) was adopted because it productively combines textual with social theoretical analysis, and thus, helped to analyze how education hubs are discursively produced, and how discursive constructs are sedimented into social structures. Two main data sets were used: *first*, 60 documents for Singapore and 38 documents for the UAE, which included political speeches, laws/legal acts, plans and strategies, reports, studies, and websites, and *second*, 9 semi-structured interviews in both countries—18 in total—with experts in the areas of policy, education industry, and academia (Witzel, 2000; Meuser & Nagel, 2009). Because this chapter discusses socio-political conditions in the education hubs Singapore and the UAE to explore geopolitical transformations pursued through their education hub projects, it focuses on the transversal dimension of both cases that explores how a phenomenon has changed over time by connecting the horizontal and vertical scales (see Bartlett & Vavrus, 2017, p. 92). Thus, it primarily draws from the analyzed documents as they “do a great deal of representational work to establish problems”, solutions, and plans and help illuminate “the broader sociopolitical contexts of relevance” (ibid.).

12.3 International Education Hubs in Policy and Research

This section *first* describes education hubs as an emerging phenomenon and discusses the existing body of research. *Second*, it describes the research gap that the chapter and its related project attempt to address.

As a phenomenon, education hubs are emerging in Singapore, the UAE, Qatar, Hong Kong, Malaysia, Botswana, South Korea, Sri Lanka, Mauritius, and Bahrain (Knight, 2014), and the number of countries appears to be growing. Simultaneously, scholars and policy makers have been promoting education hubs as a model for policy making by using the name ‘International Education Hubs’ (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014). Thus, the emergence and growth of this phenomenon might be related to a positive reception of the International Education Hub model as a development approach within policy circles. To guide local experts in the implementation of the International Education Hub model and measure their progress, Knight (2014) developed a three-staged typology ranging from student, to talent, to knowledge-innovation hubs, with the latter being presented as the most advanced stage of a hub in combination with other parameters that policy makers can measure

(see Knight, 2014). Knight (2014) defines education hubs that commonly exist at the country-level as “a planned effort to build a critical mass of local and international actors strategically engaged in crossborder education, training, knowledge production and innovation initiatives” (p. 20; see Lane and Kinser (2011, p. 82) for an alternative definition). In addition to these policy advocacy-oriented contributions, international comparative higher education research (INCHER) scholars started to explore changes in the higher education systems of education hub countries. There is an increasing body of research on changing international student and faculty flows, or satellite campuses of American, British, or Australian universities in education hub countries. For example, Yale university has a presence in Singapore, or New York University in Abu Dhabi, that increasingly attract international students and are said to contribute to building “World Class Research-Universities” in countries like Singapore or the UAE (Altbach & Salmi, 2011; Kosmützky, 2018). However, other scholars caution that through such satellite campuses, universities are, in essence, part of soft power projects, and that this entanglement in soft power may have thus-far understudied consequences for universities (Nye, 2005; Lee, 2015; Tan, 2016). Outside of INCHER, a group of human geographers recently conducted a study on so-called branch campuses in several education hub locations (Kleibert et al., 2020). The authors find a concentration of satellite campuses in locations such as Dubai (UAE), Singapore, Shanghai, and Doha (Qatar), and that a clustering of these campuses commonly signals that these are part of larger education hub strategies and/or projects.

Based on these existing findings and the different aspects of the same phenomenon that scholars have illuminated—such as higher education internationalization, soft power, as well as larger government strategies and projects in which higher education is embedded—one could argue that an empirical exploration of the phenomenon within its social, political, and economic contexts could contribute new and valuable findings. Even though selected developments within national higher education sectors have been explored conceptually, a deeper understanding of how the implementation of education hub approaches impacts higher education policy and governance is currently missing. This focus on policy, in particular, would be beneficial because the available literature indicates that governments’ pursuit of education hub projects attempts to achieve at least two overarching goals: *First*, to create a local environment that enables states to develop economically, particularly by promoting forms of knowledge-based competition, for which higher education and research are regarded as central components (i.e., the state as a competing organism, see Bachmann & Toal, 2019, p. 144; also Moisio, 2018). *Second*, in addition to these politico-economic interests, states that implement education hub approaches at the country level also want to advance their position and reputation on the global political stage, which predominantly concerns cultural-diplomatic interests. Thus, both goals, with their politico-economic and cultural-diplomatic objectives, signal that states embed higher education within larger, political projects that closely link higher education policy with geopolitical and economic activities, including cultural diplomacy. Even though international student flows and satellite campuses are single aspects of this larger phenomenon, a broader, system-level

perspective could capture some of the wider implications of the education hub approach on higher education policy and governance. Because such a perspective is currently missing, this chapter and the larger empirical project to which it is related attempt to address this existing research gap.

12.4 The Development and Implementation of Education Hub Projects and Strategies in Singapore and the UAE Between 1990 and 2018

Guided by the CCS approach (see Bartlett & Vavrus, 2017, p. 92, in particular) and CPE, this section pays particular attention to how the education hub phenomenon developed and why it was implemented by political actors in both Singapore and the UAE. As described earlier, what is currently missing in existing research is a deeper dive into the “broader sociopolitical and economic contexts” (Bartlett & Vavrus, 2017, p. 89) of education hubs, and a broader perspective on the role of universities in those contexts (see previous section). This is particularly important because empirically-informed knowledge about the politico-economic and cultural-diplomatic dimensions of education hubs is, nonetheless, crucial to understanding the phenomenon better, as scholars have stressed soft power, cultural diplomacy, and commerce as important yet understudied aspects (Lee, 2015; Tan, 2016; or also Erfurth, 2019).

Arguably, such a perspective is also valuable to explore geopolitical transformations because it illuminates how and why both Singapore and the UAE are pursuing such transformations by implementing education hubs as a development approach. Therefore, this section, *first*, describes both education hub approaches that are implemented in Singapore and the UAE as state-led, geopolitical projects. *Second*, it illuminates the cultural-diplomatic dimensions of both projects, followed by *third*, discussing the politico-economic dimensions of both projects. This disentanglement of both dimensions by country/case contributes a new, comparative perspective on researching education hubs and is an attempt to cope with the incredible policy-mix that one finds when studying the phenomenon in each case (that includes higher education policy and governance combined with politics in the areas of development, diplomacy, economy, culture, location and the wider social sphere). Arguably, this policy-mix is one reason why understandings of the phenomenon remain fuzzy in both research and policy as it is hard to clearly define it simply as a higher education phenomenon or one of, for example, development economics. Thus, this chapter’s adopted perspective does not study higher education by its different subject matters (such as student flows, internationalization strategies, among others), but rather looks at higher education as an object that is changed by different political actors inside and outside of the sector to achieve objectives that are related to geopolitics (or, put differently, as a tool to pursue geopolitical transformations through cultural-diplomatic and politico-economic means). Last, *fourth*, this

section uses the discussion of the phenomenon's dimensions to explore some of its geopolitical implications and the transformations pursued by states such as Singapore or the UAE.

12.4.1 The Political and Economic Contexts of Singapore's and the UAE's Education Hub Projects

This sub-section, *first*, describes Singapore's education hub project and its rationales, and *second*, describes the same in the context of the UAE. Both descriptions embed the countries' education hub projects within wider socio-political and economic contexts that ultimately drove changes within their higher education sectors.

Singapore's ambitions to develop a country-level education hub are arguably related to the end of the Cold War and the shakeup of the global order. In the greater scheme of things, one might say that market capitalism succeeded over communism in the early 1990s. This meant that an increasing number of (formerly) communist countries likely started changing their production, trade, and consumption, which was a great business opportunity for the global private sector. Its geographic location placed Singapore, a former British colony, in proximity to the former "communist world." Singapore's political leadership arguably saw that it could benefit significantly from new business if it could signal that, out of the many shipping ports available for facilitating trade in the region—including neighboring Malaysia, or Indonesia—it could function as the regional gateway—a hub—to the Asian economies that were likely to reform as a haven for both capital and companies from the capitalist West. In this respect, Singapore made some very strategic decisions in the early 1990s that signaled not only its embracing of capitalism but also a desired closer ideological association with the US as a strong advocate of market capitalism and the world's main superpower and positioned itself as a hub of many sorts, such as in aviation, banking/finance, and other sectors. Part of this hub-transformation was also higher education, with Singapore implementing a large, state-led project that later became known as its education hub approach (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014).

The UAE arguably observed Singapore's rapid development in the 1990s and decided to also establish itself as a regional hub. Even though the exact beginning of the UAE's country-level education hub project remains fuzzy, it most likely began around the time of several leadership changes in 2004 (and following years) in the emirates of Abu Dhabi and Dubai as well as at the federal UAE level. Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed al Nahyan, the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, and Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid al Maktoum, Ruler of Dubai, Vice President and Prime Minister of the UAE, both took the reins to continue the modernization agendas their fathers had begun (see also Jones, 2017, pp. 49–50). Part of this modernization was—and still is—a reduction of the government's reliance on oil revenues for its budget, a strategy that economists call economic diversification. With the Middle

East region thrown into war and crisis at the time, the new leadership shifted its focus and attempted to rapidly integrate into the global, rather than regional, economic system. In combination with economic diversification, global economic integration became the driving factor of the UAE's state-led development project. However, the UAE's attempts for global economic integration have significant differences between Abu Dhabi and Dubai. This matters because even though the UAE is a federation of seven emirates, this chapter's data analysis shows that policy and governance in the UAE are mostly driven at the federal emirate level, at least in Abu Dhabi and Dubai.

A big challenge to global integration at the time was that the UAE is located within a region that large parts of the world associated with a negative image. Thus, the UAE's state projects included attempts to change this perception into a more progressive image of the UAE to support its recognition on the world stage, with higher education and research playing an important part. Although absent at the national level, federal-level higher education projects have become central to an attempted association with more progressive and modern values, such as the use of cultural artifacts in Abu Dhabi in particular, and have thereby become strategic elements for its development. As stated earlier, the UAE attempted to establish itself as a hub as its general approach to development. A central part of this hub-transformation are its current higher education projects that later became known as its education hub approach (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014).

12.4.2 The Cultural-Diplomatic Dimensions of Singapore's and the UAE's Education Hub Projects

Re-shaping the world's perception about both Singapore and the UAE are central to their current development approaches. Thus, one geopolitical transformation that both countries pursue is a more central, important role they want to play in the international community, and that the same community accepts both states as equals (in terms of their developmental state). However, as discussed earlier, neither state is so-far signaling to pursue the social and political institution building that the international community usually promotes and requires. In this context, Singapore's and the UAE's education hubs have a very distinct cultural-diplomatic dimension: Both countries developed political strategies that use higher education as a tool that helps alleviate their positions on the global stage even though they, to date, bypass important aspects such as institution building. Through such strategies, both countries have developed a reputation for being places where talent and companies move as entrepreneurs and innovators, with Singapore arguably being more successful in this regard compared to the UAE, and both countries hosting important international summits or act as brokers/mediators in regional conflicts.

Singapore began to discuss its first attempts to attract scientists, researchers, and executives to increase its chances of becoming the location in Asia that global

companies would choose for their regional headquarters in the early 1990s. Therefore, the drivers of these first attempts were largely politico-economic. What might seem like a minuscule decision, yet one that was predicated on a change in the order of discourse at the time, was the idea of launching a strategy called “Boston of the East,” implemented in 1996 and 1997, and which was likely influenced by the then ongoing Asian financial crisis. Boston is known for being an important place in the US for science and innovation, and in combination with that, economic power. However, at the time, a place with comparable attributes was missing in Asia. Thus, Singapore attempted to replicate the mechanics of Boston’s success—higher education, research, and commerce—in the city-state to re-invent itself as the “Boston of the East”. As the region was in crisis, this decision signaled that Singapore decided to shift its focus from regional to global integration, with the global economy as its new frontier, and its education hub project providing the driving factor for such pursuit; to become a globally reputed location for higher education and research. As a consequence, Singapore launched a higher education project that aimed at distinguishing the city state from its own region to stand out as the best place to do business in Asia. It decided to remodel the National University of Singapore (NUS), and—perhaps very strategically—the Nanyang Technological University (NTU) that was founded by the Chinese, and which was therefore a potential signifier of communism, after Harvard University and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. This was the start of a higher education regional project ideologically associated with market capitalism, and the US in particular, that placed higher education at its core, signaling that Singapore would also accordingly educate its elites and future leadership (see also Barr, 2014).

One component of this project was to develop closer diplomatic ties with the US, “one of its [Singapore’s] best friends (though never a formal ally)” (Barr, 2018, p. 121), through cultural exchange, in particular higher education. However, Singapore also wanted to become the place for (re)educating the regional elites in the wake of policy reforms by Asian neighbors that were beginning to embrace market capitalism. Thus, it saw these neighbors rather as competitors than friends against which it needed to succeed in regional competition and wanted to build the capacity to influence regional politics by educating future political, social, and business elites and exert soft power. The scope of the educational offerings in Singapore ranged from training for company executives to future Singaporean public administrators, as well as those of its neighbors, which meant both income and, more importantly, influence through higher education and partnerships. For instance, the Harvard Kennedy School set up a policy program with the NUS in 1992, which later became the reputed Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy that educates the national and regional policy elite. With hypothetically comparable reasons in mind, New York University Tisch School of the Arts was set up to educate the regional creative elite (this, however, ultimately failed), with Yale-NUS being another current pioneer project as the first and most reputed liberal arts college in the region since 2011. Singapore can be considered to have been successful with its Boston of the East regional project, which entails transforming NUS and NTU into reputed global universities, modeled after the American Ivy League and the way in which it

attracts scientists and students to attend those universities by positioning itself as a reputed location for higher education and research; or, rather, the prime location for that matter on the Asian continent, which is a geopolitical transformation it ultimately wanted to achieve. This cultural-diplomatic project with a hardly quantifiable outcome (yet presumably high intangible return) is ongoing and one that is largely financed by the Singaporean government. This is noteworthy because it is very different from projects and strategies that are illuminated with regards to Singapore's education hub's politico-economic dimension that is discussed later.

Even though the UAE's most prominent emirate is Dubai, its capital is Abu Dhabi, and the emirate has become a sophisticated regional and global player that uses cultural diplomacy to influence politics. One could discuss higher education in Abu Dhabi from a marketization perspective as the emirate has a growing private higher education sector with, for instance, INSEAD or the Abu Dhabi University. However, its state-funded, rather niche-higher education sector is particularly relevant for this discussion of geopolitical transformations and cultural-diplomatic projects that impact higher education and policy. Its massive oil and gas reserves position the UAE's capital in a favorable position to finance the operations of highly reputed international universities, such as the New York University Abu Dhabi (NYUAD). By populating its cultural landscape with foreign, high-culture artifacts, the emirate associates itself with the reputation of those artifacts to achieve a recognition as a socially progressive place that supports the arts, higher education, and research: "The UAE was built on our Founding Father Sheikh Zayed's foundational values of tolerance and peace, and stability. His guiding strategy was to show friendship towards all cultures and peoples, to promote moderate Islam and to work for mutually advantageous cooperation with all nations" (MoFAIC, 2020). By hosting so-called world-class museums, such as the Louvre Abu Dhabi, and universities, in particular a renowned liberal arts university such as NYUAD but also the Sorbonne, the emirate signals that global high culture and academic rigor are both welcome and desired in the Middle East, and Abu Dhabi has culturally as much to offer as "global cities" like Paris or New York. The signaling is simple, but the effect on the country and the international reputation it has gained is enormous: "In 2020, the UAE ranked first in the region and 18th internationally in the Global Soft Power Index. This is a testament to the nation's on-going commitment to ensuring an environment of opportunity, innovation, development and tolerance" (MoFAIC, 2020). Although this development is not solely attributable to the described higher education reforms the emirate has implemented, they play an important role. Hence, the cultural-diplomatic dimension of Abu Dhabi's education hub project pursues greater regional and global influence as a targeted geopolitical transformation and is an attempt to project an image of progressiveness to the world.

12.4.3 The Politico-Economic Dimensions of Singapore's and the UAE's Education Hub Projects

Singapore's "Boston of the East"-idea discussed earlier epitomizes the politico-economic dimension of the geopolitical transformation that both Singapore and the UAE pursue through their education hub approaches: Replicating the impact that Boston has on the American economy by attracting universities, students, and companies, believing this combination will create the desired effects in Singapore and the UAE to advance their local economies. Thus, the goal is to become the most reputed, regional places for higher education, research, and knowledge-intensive work, which again, contributes to being perceived as highly developed countries by peers on the global stage. Universities, their faculty, and students are also regarded as knowledge workers and a significant economic factor as they pay taxes, rents, and have general spending activities from which the economy benefits. The political strategies put in place in both hubs to achieve this Boston of the East-idea was a rapid expansion of their private higher education sectors, combined with the liberalization of entry requirements for universities to operate in local sectors. Thus, in terms of the politico-economic dimension of education hubs, both countries have established free-market environments for higher education industries with the expectation of direct returns to their economies. However, an important finding for higher education policy, universities as actors, and students as learners is that even though the projects have helped both Singapore and the UAE to achieve their desired geopolitical transformations, the bottom line is that these projects come with risks for both universities and students that usually remain overlooked in discussions about education hubs.

Singapore's private higher education sector expansion began with the desire of its leadership to tap into the growing international higher education market in the 1990s. Its Economic Development Board and its parent organization, the Ministry for Trade and Industry, in coordination with the Ministry of Education, began to promote and push for attracting well established "world-class universities" to the island. The aim was to create and commercialize an international higher education sector by attracting students and universities (Ng & Tan, 2010) whose contribution to the national economy was then measured and reported in these organizations' annual reports. After initial successes in the late 1990s, Singapore launched a strategy that, since 2002, has become more widely known as the "Global Schoolhouse". However, the project began delivering below-expectation outcomes and arguably led to market failure epitomized by the opening of an Australian university in March 2007 and its closure in June of the same year (Ng & Tan, 2010). This led to a silent death of the education hub project, a doubling down on regulation and quality assurance, and several subsequent attempts to fix the regulation of its private higher education sector.

With regards to the UAE, the focus of the politico-economic dimension of its education hub is not on its capital Abu Dhabi but the emirate Dubai. Contrary to Abu Dhabi, it cannot rely on income generated by business from oil and gas

resources and, therefore, positioned itself as the central regional location for logistics, air travel, tourism, or business, and has succeeded in coining the term “hub” for itself. The emirate has had tremendous success in implementing this strategy through the wide use of the economic zones it has created. For instance, the Dubai International Financial Center is a dedicated area of business park-sized buildings that imitates/adopts British law so that companies and bankers in Dubai can trade almost as if they were in the City of London. Since 2003, the UAE has been experiencing an accelerating influx of expats. This has to do with the country’s development, which, in turn, provides many employment opportunities in the service sector. In combination, this trend has created a labor market that increasingly needs skilled labor and a growing expat population, with children who attend private schools and universities for expats. For this reason, there has been an increase in the number of private international universities being founded in Dubai in particular: two in 2004, four in 2005, and four in 2006, only counting those that are still operational, and being aware that several have had to close. In addition, this increase might also be related to a desired social change through more modern education by the country’s leadership to prepare citizens better for the global economy, as promoted in current strategies such as Vision 2021.

Arguably, while pursuing a larger project that attempts to combine global integration with economic diversification, both the international universities and the emirate of Dubai recognized that the growing number of expats and Dubai’s increasing popularity might turn international higher education into a business opportunity. However, to prevent the exploitation of students and parents, the emirate founded a quality assurance agency, the Knowledge and Human Development Authority in 2006, after which the numbers of private university incorporations per year have declined. Thus, this could be interpreted as a doubling down on regulation and quality assurance in the sector. In addition, the world was hit by the global financial crisis in 2007 and 2008, after which new incorporations of private universities have remained steady with, on average, only one per year. Today, Dubai has the second highest number of branch campuses in the world (33), behind China (36) (EY Parthenon, 2019), most of which are located in dedicated economic zones for higher education and training services that host most of these branches in business park-sized buildings.

In recent years, Dubai’s quality assurance agency and its economic zones for education have started to push the label education hub for the emirate to increase the number of inbound international students and universities. In Dubai’s case, the creation of physical agglomerations of branch campuses in its economic zones have led to a reputation for the emirate to be perceived as an education hub by others (Knight, 2014). In policies, its hub is described as significantly contributing to Dubai’s economic diversification, particularly the associated skilled labor needs, as well as helping to project a more progressive, metropolitan image of the emirate. The project to transform Dubai into a hub and to move from the sole provision of teaching through importing branch campuses to creating a space for research, is described as the long-term goal of this project. Currently, this project can be regarded as the

creation of an international higher education industry in Dubai with the goal of generating profit for investors and providers, in particular.

12.4.4 Geopolitical Implications and Transformations Through Education Hubs

The discussion of the phenomenon's politico-economic and cultural-diplomatic dimensions in Singapore and the UAE arguably illuminates both geopolitical implications and transformations. Thus, this sub-section draws the two conceptual lines of 11.4.2 and 11.4.3 together to, *first*, describe some geopolitical implications for the international development community and its current landscape. *Second*, these implications are generated by the geopolitical transformations that are pursued by education hub countries such as Singapore and the UAE, which are also being discussed.

First, in terms of geopolitical implications for development, education hub countries' strategic use of higher education expansion leads the development community to support this approach because this community promotes the same expansion as a development parameter (British Council, 2013; OECD IMHE, 2014). In addition, this community rewards education hubs with a recognition as socially and economically progressive countries, which, in turn, leads to an increasing prominence of the approach in policy circles, particularly in Asia. Nonetheless, the geopolitical implications that the development community so-far overlooks are that this approach to development creates regional winners and losers and increases competition for students, universities, and companies. It is contrary to other, more collaborative approaches that are usually promoted, such as in the European Union. Also, because the approach allows the avoidance of social and political institution building that IOs and other players commonly promote, the influence of traditional players that also promote democracy on the global stage, including their arguments, might decrease. Considering that nearly all education hubs are strategic geopolitical locations—such as Hong Kong with its increasing influence from China, the UAE as an emerging diplomatic player in the Middle East and its newly brokered relationships with Israel, and also Singapore with a similar role in South-East Asia—the support for this model risks to undermine the development community's efforts to advocate for a more democratic, socially progressive world.

Second, the geopolitical transformations that education hub countries pursue, which are a greater role on the global political stage and economic diversification, increase the competition between countries and the aspect of regional winners and losers discussed earlier. More importantly for INCHER and universities as actors, these transformations create a politicized environment for universities in which they are both central subjects and objects of diplomacy. Even though this chapter does not specifically focus on universities, the exploration of the phenomenon's politico-economic and cultural-diplomatic dimensions illuminates education hubs as higher

education policy and governance environments. Because the education hub approach—based on the analysis of Singapore and the UAE—does not desire universities to contribute to the development of local social and political institutions more widely, their social function is different from the role that they historically played in, for example, Europe’s social and economic development (Fisch, 2015). Arguably, universities are stripped of such wider social functions and are predominantly seen as economic tools for research output and the production of graduates for knowledge-based economies. Thus, even though degrees and programs have similar names, the students’ experience at European or American satellite universities in education hubs are likely to be different from the ones they would have in universities’ home countries—because of the lack of universities’ wider social functions in education hubs. Also, the undesired social and political contribution of universities and their scholars in local contexts might be one reason why most programs that are offered are in the natural sciences, and, for example, not in the social sciences. Even though these are important issues for both higher education policy and provision, research and debates on these matters remain scarce.

12.5 Conclusion

This chapter departed from the paradoxical observation that even though the education hub approach is one that contradicts development approaches that are promoted by the international community because it bypasses social and political institution building, the same community regards education hub countries as progressive because of this adoption. In addition, countries such as Singapore are lauded for their development. Thus, as I will argue below, the phenomenon has several geopolitical implications. At the same time, the previous discussion of the state of research about this phenomenon showed that scholars promote it as a model for policy making, primarily discuss it in equally affirmative ways as the development community, and that empirical findings are scarce. In addition, most research perspectives narrowly focus on hub-countries’ higher education sectors, which partly explains why the current education hub debate more generally has a strong focus on higher education internationalization. Therefore, contrary to more prominent contributions that promote education hubs as an approach to system-level higher education internationalization (Lane & Kinser, 2011; Knight, 2014), this chapter adds to an emerging debate that articulates the soft power and cultural diplomatic aspects of the phenomenon but so far remains outside of broader social scientific discussions (Lee, 2015). Although the chapter’s focus on Singapore and the UAE and the analysis of policy documents as a singular source limits its scale, scope, and ability to make general assumptions about the larger phenomenon, it illuminates that higher education in the hubs Singapore and the UAE is rather an object/tool in the pursuit of geopolitical transformations than a sector that is internationalized for the benefit of learners and educators. In addition, it shows that social and political institution building is substituted by market liberalization, infrastructure development, and the attraction

of foreign universities and other players. Thus, the approach risks that Singapore's and the UAE's recent development is rather short-lived. More broadly, research on the phenomenon and its consequences for universities and geopolitics is scarce, and this chapter lacks the wider empirical basis to discuss these aspects further. However, they are central for discussions about development more broadly, and for higher education internationalization more specifically that so far avoid articulating some of the challenging, rather controversial, and under-studied aspects of higher education's recent global expansion.

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